



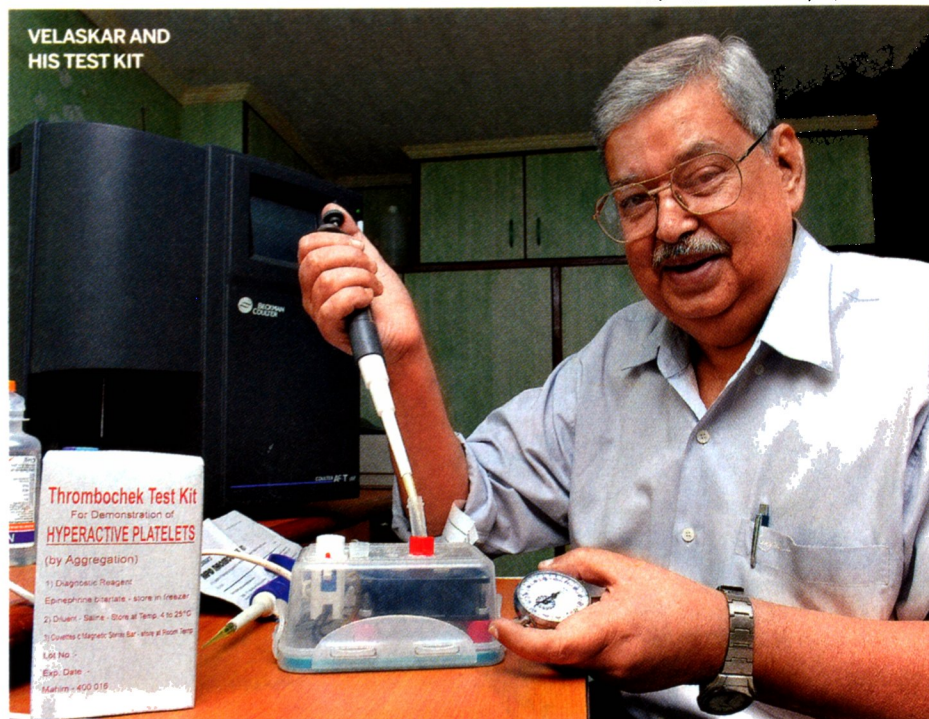
**MASTERMIND
INDIA**

Spirit of India Special

STROKE BUSTER

Heat diseases claim a large number of lives each year, but Dr Dilip Shrinivas Velaskar may have just found a way to predict the probability of who it could strike and when. Dr Velaskar has devised a test to measure the hyperactivity of platelets, which can show whether a person is at risk of suffering from a stroke. His innovation—the rapid thrombocheck test kit—is a quick and economical way to conduct what is known as an aggregometry test. The process is otherwise cumbersome and expensive. It can be conducted only three hours after collecting the sample, requires an expert technician and costs about Rs 3,000. The new kit will cut the cost to Rs 250-300 for the end user as the Rs 600 kit can be used 10 times, and the time to within half an hour of collecting samples.

A practising pathologist for the last 30 years in Mumbai, Dr Velaskar graduated from the Faculty of Ayurvedic Medicine, University of Bombay, where he studied both ayurveda and allopathy. He trained under senior pathologist Dr V.H. Salaskar. Setting up an independent practice was a challenge, but things became better after his wife Kalpana joined him. She is a pathologist and blood transfusion consultant who has worked with Lilavati and Hinduja hospitals. "Pathology is the basis for



Dr Dilip SHRINIVAS VELASKAR, 68

INNOVATION

**Rapid thrombocheck
test kit**

SELLING PRICE

Rs 600

WHAT IT DOES

**Tests blood to
determine if a person
runs the risk of a
heart attack**

**THE NEW KIT WILL
CONVERT WHAT IS
A CUMBERSOME
PROCESS INTO A
QUICKER, EASIER
AND CHEAPER TEST.**

understanding most ailments and that was what attracted me most," he says. He would spend hours researching the behaviour of platelets at Dr Salaskar's laboratory in Opera House. That's where he found a direct relation between hyperactive platelets and strokes.

It has been a long journey to create this seemingly simple test kit, which he started putting together in 2000. With no sponsorships for the research, progress depended on the availability of time and money. But Velaskar stuck to the idea because he believed in it. "I am sure it will have far-reaching consequences and will affect many lives across the world. It must go to everyone." Help eventually came from the government through the Technopreneur Promotion Programme. The Rs 8 lakh that he got through it over three years sped up the process. He is also awaiting an international patent and has received offers from both national and international pharmaceutical companies. He hopes to see it in the market in about six months. For him it's the culmination of years of research. For the rest of us, it's the chance of a healthier future.

by Nishat Bari